



YASIN DAR

A DESTROYED HOUSE AT PAKHERPORA, PULWAMA, WHERE SECURITY FORCES ENGAGED INFILTRATORS IN A FIERCE GUNBATTLE



The New TERROR THREAT

Sophisticated equipment and weapons, increasingly fierce encounters and the coming together of terror groups show the change in the ISI's Kashmir strategy

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

There's a new phrase being used by the security forces guarding the LoC to describe infiltration attempts from across the border. It's now called "armed intrusion". That's because of the new infiltration strategy that has rung alarm bells from South Block to Srinagar where security forces are stunned by the advanced levels of training, equipment and the sheer numbers that are attempting to infiltrate into India.

So daring and well-planned is the strategy that while reviewing the se-

curity situation in Kashmir during inter-ministerial meetings, comparisons were being made with Kargil 1999. One outcome is that the army and other security forces are contemplating holding on to their positions in the upper reaches of Kashmir instead of vacating them till the snow begins to melt. This is a direct result of events of the last three weeks where areas along the LoC witnessed eight fierce encounters. The army suffered one of its worst reverses while fighting infiltrators in the Hafruda forests of Kupwara in an encounter that lasted almost a week, starting March 20. While 17 Lashkar-e-Toiba

(LeT) men were killed, the army lost eight of its paracommandos, including a major. "We had intelligence and were ready to stop them but the ferocity of their defiance and the willingness to engage so readily took us by surprise," says an intelligence official.

Even the number of infiltrators who managed to breach the LoC was unexpected. Till last year, infiltrators used to enter in small groups of four and five to avoid detection. But now they are pushing into India in groups of 25 to 30. It is almost like platoon-level intrusions, according to sources. This time the infiltrators came in